

side support—have threatened his Government, and JMM—the largest constituent of his Government—is never tired of reminding him that what goes up, must come down.

When pushed into a corner, Koda, however, has also shown steel of character. Last month, he appointed P.P. Sharma as the new chief secretary despite protests from two independent ministers, Bandhu Tirkey and Bhanu Pratap Shahi. They publicly threatened to resign and withdraw support but Koda managed to placate them.

Again, Koda offered to “resign in two minutes to make way for Soren” when a section of JMM leaders, and a few sulking independent ministers, made a fervent pitch for “Guruji” to be made chief minister after his acquittal in a murder case. Within a week, however, they had to capitulate because both the Congress and RJD rejected the move.

“We knew Soren will not be open to reason and be as accommodating as Koda is,” says a senior RJD leader. Similarly, Deputy Chief Minister Stephen Marandi’s open revolt for the energy portfolio was nipped in the bud with a no-nonsense “take what I give or leave it” message from Koda.

As for Soren, his support to Koda is borne out of compulsion as he does not have the numbers to cobble together a majority on his own. The RJD and the Congress have refused to back him and he is not prepared to switch allegiance to the BJP. Despite his strategic failures, he has emerged as a parallel power centre in Jharkhand, who keeps demanding a larger say in matters of governance. Last week, when Koda and his friends were busy celebrating one year in office, Soren shot off a six-page letter to the chief minister, that was also released to the press, alleging that his government machinery suffers from acute “commission culture”.

In times of crisis, Koda has had strong supporters, with Lalu being the most prominent. It was Lalu who made Koda offer Soren a graceful withdrawal and an official chamber in the state secretariat. It was

he who convinced the Centre to not foist President’s Rule on Jharkhand when a section of Congress MLAs clamoured for it a month ago. The reasons for the Congress and RJD backing Koda are not far to seek. The two parties, with comatose organisational set-ups and no leadership in Jharkhand, want to revive their fortunes in

MR CONSENSUS: Koda has an uncanny ability to carry everyone along



SURVIVAL TACTICS

HUMOUR ALL PARTNERS

Congress and the RJD hope to revive their political fortunes by hopping on to the Koda bandwagon. An accommodating Koda also has Lalu’s steadfast support.

KEEP DELHI HAPPY

Disgruntled Congress MLAs are forced to toe the Koda line by the party leadership in Delhi. Five out of seven RJD MLAs have formed a separate pressure group in Jharkhand but Lalu’s diktat keeps them in check.

DO NOT FEAR OPPOSITION

Knows where to stand firm as his opponents are not in a strong position. BJP is weak after five MLAs turn into rebels, JMM lacks the numbers to put together a majority and the Congress and RJD refuse to back Soren.

LACK OF COMPETITION

Other independent ministers don’t have the cross-party support to emerge as an alternative to Koda, five of whom also have defection charges pending against them.

the state with a friendly government at the helm.

Koda has been cashing in on this TINA (there is no alternative) factor. Jharkhand is perhaps the only state where one Forward Bloc MLA, Aparna Sengupta, sits in the Opposition while an expelled MLA from the party, Shahi, is a cabinet minister. Similarly, All Jharkhand Student Union (AJSU) legislator Chandra Prakash Choudhary is a minister while party chief Sudesh Mahto mans the Opposition benches of the Assembly.

The chief minister knows how to win friends and influence people in the political minefield that is Jharkhand. In the recent presidential elections, Pratibha Patil got 49 votes from the state—more than the UP’s strength in the Assembly. But, if the switching of allegiance by the independents gave Koda the opportunity he needed, the split within

BJP and the disqualification threat to 13 legislators has helped him consolidate his wafer-thin majority.

Five suspended BJP MLAs, who joined Jharkhand Vikas Morcha of rebel MP Babulal Marandi, have not been unfriendly to the Government, primarily because the Speaker has issued notices to them under the anti-defection provisions. Five independent ministers—Anosh Ekka, Bandhu Tirkey, Shahi, Stephen Marandi and Kamlesh Singh—have defection charges pending against them, forcing them to be in Koda’s good books.

But is Koda a man of the present, with no future? Though the chief minister denies having any plans of forming his own party, his confidants concede that he is scripting his future for another stint in charge of the state. For now, he knows that he has to survive to achieve his dream. Ironically, he never wanted to be a politician as he was keen on the army. Despite being an ace shooter with an ‘A’ certificate from the National Cadet Corps, Koda could not make it in three attempts because of his five-feet-four-and-a-half-inch frame. The shooting skills, it appears, are coming in handy now. ■